

Several years ago someone talked me into running a 10K (6.4 mile) race. Before the race started, everyone was excited. Some were talking about how good of shape they were in, others were bragging about how fast they were going to run and some were just jumping around and acting crazy.

When they announced that the race would soon begin, people started to line up. The faster runners pushed toward the front while the slower runners headed toward the rear. I hate to be behind, so I moved to the front with the world class runners. Needless to say, that was the last time I saw them.

I was doing pretty good until about the third mile when my muscles started aching. I was tired and weak, my side started hurting and I felt dehydrated. My body began to get numb and said, "Just Quit," but something inside of me said, "Don't focus on your flesh, focus on the finish line." Even though I couldn't see it with my eyes, I could see it in my mind.

I decided to push past my feelings and keep running. Before long I had passed the six mile marker and could see the finish line ahead. Once the finish line was in sight my adrenaline started to kick in. I got my second wind and I sprinted to the finish. I actually ran faster at the end of the race than I did at the beginning.

Recently while praying, I heard in my spirit the phrase, "Finish Strong." The only way to finish strong is to have your spiritual adrenaline kick in. Your spiritual adrenaline is JOY. ***For the joy of the Lord is your strength,*** (Nehemiah 8:10 NIV). Joy is a powerful force that works on the inside to strengthen you and help you accomplish great things.

You may have some setbacks and stumbling blocks to overcome this year on your way to victory. Whether you are trying to expand your ministry, receive healing or break the spirit of debt...Joy is your answer. It will cause you to finish strong and receive the victors' crown.

Don't quit, throw in the towel or fall by the way side. God wants you to complete all that He has put in your heart to do.

Paul faced many obstacles on his way, but he said, ***none of these things move me; ...so that I may finish my race with joy,*** (Acts 20:24 NKJV). Even in the midst of many tribulations, Paul said, ***I am overflowing with joy,*** (II Corinthians 7:4 Amplified Bible).

Where does joy come from, and how do we receive it? Acts 2:28 says, ***You make me full of joy in Your presence,*** (NKJV).

So, stay in God's presence a little longer today. You are about to get your second wind, and "Finish Strong."

Great victories await you this year. The dreams and desires that you thought were out of reach will be yours. Impossibilities will become possibilities. ***The things which are impossible with men are possible with God,*** (Luke 18:27 NKJV).

For God ...*is able to [carry out His purpose and] do superabundantly, far over and above all that we [dare] ask or think [infinitely beyond our highest prayers, desires, thoughts, hopes, or dreams]*, (Ephesians 3:20 Amplified Bible).

Remember, God will not always put the grapes in your mouth, but He will put them within your reach, so, “Finish Strong.”

Finishing Strong,

Joey Hipp